

Prompt Ladder

Objective

The goal of this exercise was to improve a weak prompt by changing only one prompt layer at a time. After each change, I compared the new output with the previous one to understand which prompt engineering technique actually improved the result.

Run 0 : Baseline Prompt

Prompt

Write a case study about my internship.

Representative Output

During my internship, I gained valuable experience working on real-world projects and developing my technical skills. I collaborated with others, learned new concepts, and improved my problem-solving abilities. The experience helped me grow professionally and prepared me for future opportunities in AI and technology.

Notes

Layer Added

Baseline (No prompt engineering)

What changed in the prompt?

None.

What improved in the output?

Not applicable.

What still failed?

The output was extremely generic. It could describe almost any internship and contained no information about my actual experience.

What would I try next?

Make the goal more specific.

Run 1 : Add a Clear Goal

Prompt

Write a short portfolio case study about my internship.

Representative Output

This portfolio case study describes my internship experience and the skills I developed during the program. Through hands-on work and learning opportunities, I expanded my technical knowledge, improved my problem-solving abilities, and gained practical experience that will support my future career.

Notes

Layer Added

Clear Goal

What changed in the prompt?

I clarified that I wanted a short portfolio case study instead of a general case study.

What improved in the output?

The response became more suitable for a portfolio instead of reading like a general summary.

What still failed?

The improvement was small. The response still sounded generic and could describe almost anyone's internship.

What would I try next?

Define the audience.

Run 2 : Add an Audience

Prompt

Write a short portfolio case study about my internship for recruiters seeking AI/ML interns or entry-level candidates.

Representative Output

This internship helped me build foundational AI and machine learning skills while working on practical projects. It demonstrates my willingness to learn, adapt to new technologies, and prepare for an entry-level AI or machine learning role.

Notes

Layer Added

Defined Audience

What changed in the prompt?

I specified that the audience was recruiters looking for AI/ML interns or entry-level candidates.

What improved in the output?

The response focused more on skills and professional growth that recruiters would care about instead of describing the internship in general terms.

What still failed?

The output still lacked any details about my own internship and sounded generic.

What would I try next?

Provide real context.

Run 3 : Add Real Context

Prompt

Write a short portfolio case study about my internship for recruiters seeking AI/ML interns or entry-level candidates. I am completing the FlyRank AI Engineering Internship, where I

am learning Python, machine learning, and AI by working on real projects using a large-scale warehouse dataset.

Representative Output

During my FlyRank AI Engineering Internship, I have been building practical skills in Python, machine learning, and AI by working with a large-scale warehouse dataset. Through hands-on projects, I have learned how machine learning notebooks are structured, explored AI workflows, and strengthened my ability to learn new technical concepts through practical experience.

Notes

Layer Added

Real Context

What changed in the prompt?

I added details about the internship, what I was learning, and the type of work I was doing.

What improved in the output?

The response became much more specific to my experience and no longer sounded like a generic internship description.

What still failed?

The response was still written as one narrative and did not clearly explain the problem, decisions, and outcome.

What would I try next?

Specify the output format.

Run 4 : Add an Output Format

Prompt

Write a short portfolio case study about my internship for recruiters seeking AI/ML interns or entry-level candidates. I am completing the FlyRank AI Engineering Internship, where I am learning Python, machine learning, and AI by working on real projects using a large-scale warehouse dataset. Organize the case study into three sections: The Problem, What I Did and Decided, and What Came of It.

Representative Output

The Problem

I wanted to learn machine learning through practical experience instead of relying only on theory.

What I Did and Decided

I explored machine learning notebooks, learned AI workflows, and used AI tools to understand unfamiliar concepts step by step.

What Came of It

I developed a better understanding of machine learning notebooks and became more confident using AI to support my learning.

Notes

Layer Added

Specified Output Format

What changed in the prompt?

I asked the AI to organize the response into three clear sections.

What improved in the output?

The response became much easier to read. Separating the problem, actions, and outcome made the case study clearer and more structured.

What still failed?

The writing still sounded somewhat like standard AI-generated text and did not fully reflect my personal voice.

What would I try next?

Add quality criteria.

Run 5 :Add Quality Criteria

Prompt

Write a short portfolio case study about my internship for recruiters seeking AI/ML interns or entry-level candidates. I am completing the FlyRank AI Engineering Internship, where I am learning Python, machine learning, and AI by working on real projects using a large-scale warehouse dataset. Organize the case study into three sections: The Problem, What I Did and Decided, and What Came of It. Use a direct, warm, plain, and specific writing style. Avoid buzzwords such as "passionate" or "results-driven." Use only the information I provide, and do not exaggerate my experience or invent achievements.

Representative Output

The Problem

I joined the FlyRank AI Engineering Internship because I wanted to learn machine learning and eventually apply it to practical mathematical problems. I believed that working on real projects would teach me more than studying theory alone.

What I Did and Decided

I started by learning how machine learning notebooks are organized and understanding the basics of AI workflows. Since I was new to machine learning, I chose a learning path that matched my current experience. When I found the terminology difficult, I used AI assistants to explain concepts step by step so I could understand them before moving on.

What Came of It

I am still at the beginning of my machine learning journey, but I now understand parts of machine learning notebooks that were completely unfamiliar when I started. I have also become better at using AI as a learning tool instead of expecting it to do the work for me.

Notes

Layer Added

Quality Criteria

What changed in the prompt?

I added instructions about tone, honesty, and writing quality.

What improved in the output?

The response became more natural, more personal, and reflected my actual learning experience instead of sounding like generic AI writing.

What still failed?

The AI still benefited from human review and editing to ensure every sentence reflected my own voice.

What would I try next?

Interview me before writing so the AI has richer information to work with.

Final Reusable Prompt

Write a short portfolio case study about my internship for recruiters seeking AI/ML interns or entry-level candidates. I am completing the FlyRank AI Engineering Internship, where I am learning Python, machine learning, and AI by working on real projects using a large-scale warehouse dataset. Organize the case study into three sections: The Problem, What I Did and Decided, and What Came of It. Use a direct, warm, plain, and specific writing style. Avoid buzzwords such as "passionate" or "results-driven." Use only the information I provide, and do not exaggerate my experience or invent achievements. If any information is missing, ask follow-up questions before writing the case study.

Reflection

This exercise showed me that the biggest improvements came from adding **real context** and **quality criteria**, while simply making the goal clearer had only a small effect. Changing one prompt layer at a time made it much easier to understand which prompt engineering techniques genuinely improved the AI's output instead of guessing what worked.